Policy & Strategy Lab

Assessment Handbook

This handbook contains everything needed to assess the Lab: the components and weights, the gate schedule, the rubrics, the feedback forms, the Case Approval Form, the AI-use policy and the entry and exit diagnostic. It rests on the Learning Outcomes and Competency Framework (Stage 2). Where a decision is still provisional, this handbook says so.

1. Principles

1. **Assess thinking through artefacts.** Every mark attaches to something the participant produced.
2. **Keep individual and group performance separate.** Only the 5 per cent pod synthesis mark is shared.
3. **Reward revision.** Gates give feedback; the portfolio is marked once, at the end, with credit for documented revision (provisional decision P-12).
4. **Use one scale everywhere.** Every rubric uses the same four levels, so feedback in Week 1 is directly useful in Week 4.

Level	Score	Meaning
Not yet	0	Missing, or does not show the competency
Foundational	1	Correct with a template and prompting; generic; limits unnoticed
Working	2	Independent, applied to own case, choices justified, main limits named. The working completion standard
Advanced	3	Tools selected and adapted, objections anticipated, evidence integrated, course changed when evidence required

2. Components and weights

Component	Weight	Assessed on	When
Workbook portfolio	35%	The ten workbooks, with revision notes	After Day 20
Evidence register	15%	The register, opened on Day 10	With the client report
Pod contribution and peer review	10%	Pod log, written peer reviews, structured peer assessment	Weekly, totalled at the end
Client report	20%	The final report and annexes	72 hours after Day 20
Presentation and defence	20%	Individual pitch and defence (15%); pod synthesis slide (5%)	Day 20

Converting scores to marks. Each rubric criterion is scored 0 to 3. A component's mark is the sum of its criterion scores divided by the maximum possible, multiplied by its weight. Example: a client report scoring 2, 2, 3, 2, 2, 1 on its six criteria earns 12 of 18, or 13.3 of 20 marks.

3. Gates

Gate	Day	Submission	Feedback returned	Domains in focus
1	5	Worksheets 1.2, 2.1, 2.2, 2.3 (revised), revision note, AI disclosure	By Day 7	A, B, C
2	10	Worksheets 3.1, 3.2, 4.1, 4.2, 4.3 (revised), revision note, AI disclosure	By Day 12	D, E1 and E2, F
3	15	Worksheets 5.1 to 5.3, 6.1 and the memo, revision note, AI disclosure	By Day 17	E, F, I1
4	19	Worksheets 7.1, 7.2, 8.1, 9.1 and the draft deck, revision note, AI disclosure	Before Day 20 (brief)	G, H, I2

A pod-checked review of each options appraisal also takes place at the end of Day 17, with one written instructor comment before Day 18 (provisional decision P-19).

Late submissions. Gate feedback is formative, so the main cost of lateness is losing feedback in time to use it. Feedback on late gate submissions is given only if time allows. The client report deadline is firm, except for documented emergencies.

4. Rubrics

4.1 Workbook portfolio (35%)

Score each criterion 0 to 3, using the domain descriptors in the Learning Outcomes and Competency Framework. The tracker codes in brackets point to the commonest weaknesses.

Criterion	What Working (2) looks like
A. Problem framing	Specific, bounded, solution-free statement; a role with authority and a real decision; success defined as a change for people (PF1 to PF3)
B. Structuring	MECE tree with stated logic, answerable leaves, pruned with reasons (ST1, ST2)
C. Causes and systems	Levels of cause separated; mechanisms stated; a sustaining loop; causal claims qualified (CA1, CA2)
D. Institutions	Authority, funding route and delivery chain named; incentives and absent voices identified (IN1, IN2)
E. Evidence (in the workbooks)	Several source types; disaggregated analysis; comparative matrix; limits stated (EV1, EV2)
F. Hypotheses	Falsifiable hypotheses with disconfirming tests and rivals; honest verdicts; Ledger tags accurate (HY1, HY2)
G. Options and choice	Distinct options and a baseline; explicit weighted criteria including distribution; sensitivity tested (DE1 to DE3)
H. Delivery	Theory of change with assumptions marked; named owners; justified approach; risk register; outcome indicators (EX1, EX2)
J. Revision	Revision notes show substantive changes in response to feedback at every gate (JU1)

Maximum 27. Domain I (communication) is assessed in the memo inside Workbook 6 under criterion E or F where relevant, and fully in the report and the defence.

4.2 Evidence register (15%)

Criterion	Not yet (0)	Foundational (1)	Working (2)	Advanced (3)
Coverage	Few sources, one type	Several sources, mostly one type	At least three types, covering each priority hypothesis	Sources chosen to test rivals as well as favourites
Reliability judgements	None	Labels without reasons	A reason for each rating, drawn from the five questions	Conflicts between sources explained
Triangulation	None	Some findings rest on one source	Main findings rest on two independent sources, or say they cannot	Independence of sources assessed, not assumed
Accuracy and verification	Errors or invented details	Incomplete citations	Complete Chicago citations, verified against originals	Methods and limits noted for key sources
Integrity	AI use undisclosed	Disclosure incomplete	AI use disclosed; every claim traced to a source	

Maximum 15 (the integrity row is scored 0 to 2, with 2 as its maximum and no Advanced level).

4.3 Pod contribution and peer review (10%)

Criterion	Working (2) looks like
Roles	Carried out the weekly pod role (chair, sceptic, evidence checker, scribe), as recorded in the pod log

Criterion	Working (2) looks like
Written peer reviews	Each review names a specific strength, a specific weakness and a specific revision
Structured peer assessment	Pod members rate each other's contribution on the peer assessment form; the instructor moderates outliers

Maximum 9.

4.4 Client report (20%)

Criterion	Working (2) looks like
Framing and structure	The first paragraph states the recommendation and the decision; the report is top-down and within the word limit
Diagnosis	Causes, institutions and actors explained, with the strongest rival addressed
Evidence	Claims at the strength the evidence supports; limitations stated; register consistent with text
Choice	Options, criteria, weights, trade-offs and sensitivity explicit; distribution addressed
Delivery	Theory of change, owners, approach, risks and indicators coherent with the recommendation
Judgement and reflection	What the recommendation gives up, and for whom; the reflection traces changes since the sealed answer to evidence

Maximum 18.

4.5 Presentation and defence (20%)

Individual (15%).

Criterion	Working (2) looks like
Pitch	Recommendation in the first minute; five slides in six minutes
Slides	Argument titles; honest charts with sources; one message per slide
Defence: directness	Answers the question asked
Defence: evidence and uncertainty	Cites evidence; concedes uncertainty where warranted; does not overstate

Maximum 12.

Pod synthesis (5%). One shared score, 0 to 3, for an insight that genuinely draws on all the pod's cases about the method, the institutions or the evidence, presented jointly.

5. Feedback

5.1 The gate feedback form

Heading	Feedback
Strongest element	
Critical weakness (with competency ID or tracker code)	
Missing dimension	
Required revision	
Next analytical task	

Example of good feedback, from the spine case: *Critical weakness: CA2. Your ward comparison shows that bins and separation move together, but older wards differ in housing too. Required revision: compare wards of similar housing type before claiming the bins caused the difference (C5).*

5.2 Tracker codes

Code	Pattern	Domain
PF1	Solution or cause embedded in the problem statement	A
PF2	Scope too broad to analyse in four weeks	A
PF3	No decision-making role, or a role without authority	A, D
ST1	Overlapping or incomplete branches	B
ST2	No prioritisation: analysing everything	B
CA1	Single-cause explanation	C
CA2	Correlation treated as causation	C, E
IN1	The government as the actor; no jurisdiction or funding route	D
IN2	Frontline workers or absent voices missing	D
EV1	One source, or one type of source	E
EV2	No year, coverage or limitation stated	E
EV3	Unverified figure or citation	E, J
HY1	Seeks only confirming evidence	F
HY2	Hypothesis cannot be tested	F
DE1	Jumps to a solution before the diagnosis is complete	G
DE2	Options are versions of one idea	G
DE3	Unexplained scores	G
EX1	Activity plan without causal logic	H
EX2	Indicators measure activity only	H
CO1	Conclusion buried	I
CO2	Topic titles instead of claims	I
CO3	Overstatement under questioning	I, J

Code	Pattern	Domain
JU1	Cosmetic revision	J

5.3 Analyst Development Tracker

One row per participant. Record the codes that appear at each gate; strike through a code once it has cleared.

Participant	Entry diagnostic (of 12)	Gate 1 codes	Gate 2 codes	Gate 3 codes	Gate 4 codes	Exit diagnostic (of 12)

5.4 Sampling the Analyst's Ledger (competency F4)

At each gate, pick ten substantive claims from across the submission, using the third claim on each of the first ten pages, or every claim if there are fewer than ten. Check each tag (fact, inference, assumption, hypothesis) against the source or reasoning given. Nine correct out of ten meets the Working standard.

6. Pod forms

6.1 Written peer review (one per case, at each gate)

Reviewer	Case reviewed	Gate

Heading	Review
One specific strength	
One specific weakness (name the branch, link, source or sentence)	
One required revision	

6.2 Pod log (kept by the scribe)

Date	Chair	Sceptic	Evidence checker	Scribe

Case	Challenge raised	Response	Change made

6.3 Structured peer assessment (end of programme, confidential)

Rate each other member of your pod from 0 to 3 on each line.

Pod member	Prepared and on time	Carried out pod roles	Gave specific, useful challenge	Helped others improve

7. Case Approval Form and feasibility rubric

7.1 Case Approval Form (submitted on Day 2)

Field	Entry
Name	
Problem statement (no cause, no solution)	
Population, place and institution	
Decision-making role and the decision it faces	
Why the problem matters	
Public data source 1, opened and checked (level and year)	
Public data source 2, opened and checked (level and year)	
Published qualitative or field-based source	
Ethical or access concerns	
Three candidate questions	

7.2 Feasibility rubric

Score each criterion 0, 1 or 2. A case needs at least 12 of 18, with no zero on evidence availability, institutional clarity or ethical safety.

Criterion	0	1	2
Specificity	A field of study	A problem, but group or place vague	One problem, group, place and institution
Public significance	Trivial	Matters to a narrow group	Clear harm, with a distributional dimension
Evidence availability	No usable public data	Some data at the wrong level	Two sources at a usable level, plus a qualitative source
Accessibility in four weeks	Sources not obtainable	Obtainable with difficulty	Already opened and checked
Institutional clarity	Nobody can act	Authority unclear or divided	A named role with authority and a real decision
Analytical complexity	No analysis needed	Too complex for four weeks	Needs the method; manageable
Actionability	No plausible options	Options exist but outside the role's power	Options within the role's power
Scope	Several states or sectors	One state, broad sector	One administrative unit and service
Ethical safety	Needs personal data or contact with vulnerable people	Sensitive, but manageable with care	Analysable from public sources without partisanship

8. AI-use policy

You may use AI tools to: suggest branches for an issue tree; propose rival hypotheses; critique a draft argument; find gaps in an analysis; improve the clarity of your own writing; suggest search terms.

You may not: use AI output as a source of facts, figures, citations, legal provisions or descriptions of institutions; submit AI-written text as your own analysis; let an AI tool choose your recommendation.

Every claim must be traced to a source you have read. AI tools invent plausible citations, figures and quotations. A citation that cannot be verified against the original document is treated as an error (code EV3), whatever its origin.

Disclose. Each gate submission and the final report carry a disclosure.

Tool used	For what	How you checked the output

Undisclosed use, or presenting AI-generated text or invented evidence as your own work, is a breach of academic integrity.

9. Academic integrity and working norms

- Your analysis, writing and recommendation must be your own. Pod members challenge and advise; they do not write each other's work.
- Cite every source you use, including slides, datasets and reports.
- Analyse institutions and incentives, not individuals. Do not attribute failures to named officials.
- Remain non-partisan. Party positions are evidence about political feasibility, not targets.
- Collect no primary data. All evidence is published or publicly available (Decision 5).
- Where a matter is before a court, analyse the policy questions without offering a view on the merits.

10. Entry and exit diagnostic

Task (45 minutes, at home). Read the case brief. Then write:

1. A problem statement of no more than 150 words.
2. The five questions you would most need answered.
3. One thing the responsible official should do, and why.

Design safeguards. Half the cohort takes Brief A at entry and Brief B at exit; the other half the reverse. Scripts are anonymised and mixed before scoring, so the assessor does not know whether a script is from entry or exit.

Brief A. Water supply in a small town (stylised)

A town of about 150,000 people receives piped water for two hours every second day. Households in higher parts of the town often receive little or none, and many buy water from private tankers at several times the municipal tariff. The municipal council's water section runs the distribution network; a state water board runs the treatment plant and bulk supply. Complaints to the council have risen. Local newspapers report illegal connections and leaking pipes. A state scheme has funded new pipelines in some wards. The council's engineer says the problem is shortage at source; the state board says the problem is losses in the town's network. Councillors want new borewells in their wards.

Brief B. Pre-school attendance in a rural block (stylised)

In a rural block, children aged three to six are enrolled at anganwadi centres, which provide supplementary nutrition and pre-school education. Records show high enrolment, but visiting officials often find few children present. Anganwadi workers say they spend much of their time on surveys and record-keeping. Some centres operate from rented rooms without space for activities. Parents in some villages send young children to private pre-schools; others keep them at home. The block's child development project officer reports to the district programme officer. A recent state order asks for daily attendance to be uploaded through a phone application.

Diagnostic rubric

Criterion	0	1	2	3
Precision of the problem statement (A1, A2)	Restates the topic	Names a problem but embeds a cause or solution, or is unbounded	Specific and solution-free; partly bounded	Specific, bounded, about outcomes for people, and names who decides
Quality of questions (B1, F1)	Generic	Relevant but overlapping or unordered	Distinct and covering the main areas	Structured, non-overlapping and prioritised
Awareness of evidence (E2, E3)	None	Mentions data in general	Names plausible specific sources	Names sources and their limits
Actionability (A4, D1, G3)	None, or a slogan	An action without an actor	An actor and an action	An actor, an action, and a reason it is feasible or its main risk

Maximum 12. The cohort's average change between entry and exit is the programme's first measure of whether it works.

11. Completion and distinction (deferred to Stage 8)

The completion standard is not yet decided. Three options are ready to apply:

Option	Rule
(a)	Working level (2) in all ten domains
(b)	Working level in at least eight domains, including A, E, G and I
(c)	An overall mark threshold across the five components

Any option may add a distinction rule, for example Advanced (3) in at least six domains. All options also require attendance at a stated minimum (for example, 18 of 20 sessions), all four gates submitted, the client report and the defence.

Suggested certificate wording. Completed the Policy & Strategy Lab, a 20-day, 40-hour intensive in structured problem-solving for Indian public policy, including an individually assessed policy analysis and defence. Avoid wording that implies a consulting qualification.

12. Grading workload

About four hours of feedback and grading per participant across the programme: four gates at about 35 minutes each, six lighter checks at about 10 minutes, and 45 minutes for the report. A single instructor can sustain a cohort of about sixteen; above that, add a teaching assistant. Test these estimates in the pilot and adjust.